

Chapter 36-1

Xu Qingzhu's fever came without warning, like a sudden summer rain—arriving swiftly and with fierce intensity.

Afraid that Xu Qingzhu's high fever might not subside and burn her brain, Liang Shi didn't dare delay for even a moment. She called the butler and told him to summon the family doctor.

The spacious living room was filled with heat.

Xu Qingzhu lay back on the sofa, feeling hot. She had already unbuttoned two buttons of her shirt but still felt it wasn't enough, so she continued reaching down to unbutton more, revealing the white lace underneath.

Liang Shi hurriedly pressed down on her hands, afraid she would directly remove her outer shirt.

But Xu Qingzhu opened her hazy eyes, tilted her head to one side, and murmured, "Liang Shi."

Liang Shi immediately responded, "I'm here."

Xu Qingzhu said, "You're pressing on me."

Liang Shi: "..."

Looking down, she saw that her hand was indeed resting on the back of Xu Qingzhu's hand, right at the position of the third shirt button.

Combined with Xu Qingzhu lying crooked on the sofa, her shirt had already shifted out of place.

The shirt button was right at her right chest area.

That place was soft and burning hot, like cotton candy that was melting.

It was so hot it made one's mouth dry.

This directly startled Liang Shi into shivering.

She immediately let go, explaining, "I-I-I... didn't mean to... to offend."

She stuttered so much she could barely complete a full sentence.

But Xu Qingzhu turned her face and smiled. Her body was too burning hot, so she needed something cool to bring down the temperature, and the person beside her was the perfect choice.

She reached out and touched Liang Shi's neck, gaining a bit of relief.

Liang Shi felt her carotid artery continuously transmitting heat, as if it would burn her entire being.

Helplessly, she took Xu Qingzhu's hand away, "I... I'll go get you... get you an ice towel."

She got up, but her hand was pulled by Xu Qingzhu.

Xu Qingzhu was already thin to begin with, and after being too busy at the company recently, she had become even more gaunt. Her long hair hung loosely, some falling on her chest, some on the sofa.

Her face was as if dyed with cherry blossom pink, especially her lips, which were redder than the most tender spring roses, but they had lost moisture. She stuck out the tip of her tongue and lightly licked them, from the edge to the lip bead. Her thoughts were probably already somewhat scattered as she bit her lip, leaving a tooth mark on her originally bright red lips.

Her two legs were casually draped on the sofa, her upper body rising and falling irregularly, making her look very uncomfortable.

"Want ice," Xu Qingzhu said.

Liang Shi frowned, "No, you have a fever."

"Ice," Xu Qingzhu still insisted. She lay there with her eyes half-closed, her lips opening and closing, revealing white pearly teeth.

Liang Shi: "...Then let go of me."

But Xu Qingzhu, after pausing for two seconds, moved her hand to Liang Shi's cooler wrist. After absorbing some coolness, she finally let go, her whole body going limp.

Liang Shi went to the refrigerator to get ice cubes, but didn't give them to her directly to eat. She found a clean towel and wrapped the ice cubes in it to help her cool down.

Having a fever meant her whole body was burning hot. Only her forehead felt slightly better, which couldn't make her entire person feel refreshed.

But it was much better than before.

Liang Shi tried to keep some distance from her, but couldn't completely avoid physical contact.

Her fingers would accidentally touch Xu Qingzhu's forehead, or lightly brush across her nose tip. When Xu Qingzhu felt her nose itch and scrunched it up, Liang Shi would become extremely nervous.

Xu Qingzhu felt physically uncomfortable and curled up on the sofa, not wanting to talk, looking pitiful.

Liang Shi simply prepared two towels—one on her forehead and one for her to hold in her hands.

But Xu Qingzhu didn't have the strength to hold it, so Liang Shi placed that one at her collarbone. Xu Qingzhu then pulled her hand to move it down a bit more.

When the family doctor arrived with the butler, the two of them were huddled together on the sofa in a strange and peculiar position.

The butler had originally called out, "Third Miss."

But after seeing the scene before him, he consciously turned around.

But Liang Shi immediately said, "Come over quickly and take a look."

After the doctor's diagnosis, it was high fever caused by overwork combined with catching cold. A few IV drips and some anti-inflammatory medicine would do the trick.

Since IV treatment was confirmed, Xu Qingzhu naturally had to be taken upstairs to her room.

But Xu Qingzhu's mind was currently muddled and she had almost no consciousness, let alone being able to walk.

In the end, it was Liang Shi who carried her up.

Alphas had great strength. Before carrying her, Liang Shi had given herself some mental preparation and secretly whispered in Xu Qingzhu's ear, "I'm going to carry you now, I don't have any bad intentions."

Xu Qingzhu mumbled something, but her voice was too quiet to make out what she said.

As Liang Shi carried her upstairs, Xu Qingzhu rubbed her head randomly in Liang Shi's embrace.

...

The normally short distance suddenly felt like it would never end.

When she placed Xu Qingzhu on the bed, Liang Shi secretly wiped the sweat from her temples.

This was indeed a very torturous thing.

The doctor set up the IV for Xu Qingzhu and left several boxes of medicine.

Afraid of any problems, Liang Shi had the butler rest in the building behind them so he could be called upon at any time.

Chapter 36-2

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Liang Shi stayed in a state of half-sleep and half-wakefulness all night.

At first, she had to watch whether the water in Xu Qingzhu's IV bottle was finished and prepare to change her to new medicine. Later, she had to worry about the needle coming out due to backflow of blood.

Xu Qingzhu's blood vessels were very thin and difficult to find. Even though the doctor was skilled and had inserted the needle properly, it was possible that any movement could cause the needle to slip out.

Liang Shi would only sleep for ten or so minutes before waking up again.

When the needle was removed, it was already past 2 AM. Xu Qingzhu's high fever still hadn't subsided, so Liang Shi used physical cooling methods to bring down her temperature.

She didn't know how many towels she had changed throughout the night. By dawn, the fever had finally broken.

In the distant sky, a pale light appeared on the horizon. The sun rose between the mountains, casting orange-red light on the skyline, and the entire city began to wake up.

Liang Shi took Xu Qingzhu's temperature and only then felt relieved enough to sleep.

However, sleeping in a chair was never comfortable, and there were only three hours left before work. She would also need to get up early to cook.

She simply rested like that for a while. Before 8 o'clock, Liang Shi's biological clock woke her up punctually.

Liang Shi looked at her watch: 7:58.

Making elaborate meals at home was impossible now; she could only make simple rice porridge and a sandwich.

She yawned sleepily, squeezing physiological tears from the corners of her eyes. She hadn't stayed up late in so long that her body felt drained. She stood up to stretch, but just as she raised her arms, she saw Xu Qingzhu slowly awakening, looking at her with those deep, unfathomable eyes that seemed to say—are you mentally ill?

Liang Shi: "..."

She awkwardly lowered her arms, "You're awake?"

Xu Qingzhu wasn't feverish to the point of stupidity and still remembered last night's events. She first raised her hand to touch her forehead, her voice still clear and cold, but hoarse from the night of high fever: "How high was my fever last night?"

"Thirty-nine degrees," Liang Shi said. "But it broke in the second half of the night."

Xu Qingzhu took a deep breath, feeling her body still had no strength, and lay back down on the bed, "Thank you."

Liang Shi said, "It's nothing."

After saying this, she paused and tentatively discussed with her: "How about you don't go to work today and work from home instead?"

Xu Qingzhu frowned, "Hmm?"

It was just a light trailing tone, but it expressed her confusion clearly.

"If that won't work, I'll also take leave and stay home to take care of you," Liang Shi said. "The doctor said this was caused by overwork. If you keep pushing yourself like this, your body will collapse before the new product launch event."

Xu Qingzhu shook her head, "No need, thank you."

Her tone was cold and distant.

Liang Shi was helpless, "What's wrong?"

"I have meetings today," Xu Qingzhu said while pressing her temples and lifting the covers to get out of bed.

She hadn't changed out of last night's clothes and had slept through the night with traces of illness. She took a deep breath and forced herself to stand up, "I appreciate your kind intentions, but I still need to go to the company."

Liang Shi: "..."

Really, no wonder you could take the company public.

But Liang Shi really couldn't bear to watch her drag her sick body to the company.

In the end, they reached a compromise: "I'll go make breakfast now. You wash up and then rest a bit. I'll drive you to the company later. You can take your medicine on the way, and I'll bring today's medicine for you. Remember to eat on time."

After saying this, she sighed again, "Forget it, I'll come to your company at noon to have lunch with you, and I'll pick you up from work in the evening."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

She had already walked to the bathroom door when she suddenly turned back to look at Liang Shi: "Don't you have to work?"

Afraid that she would refuse again, Liang Shi immediately put on a slightly impatient expression, but her words were full of concern: "You're in this condition, what work am I supposed to do?"

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

Her expression was somewhat speechless.

But Liang Shi didn't look at her anymore and headed straight out the door.

The moment she closed the door, that strange mechanical voice rang in her mind: [Ding dong! Congratulations to the host for accumulating over forty happiness points. Current happiness point balance is forty-two, misfortune point balance is six, account balance is 37,625 yuan. You're awesome! Hope the host will continue working hard and achieve even greater success!]

Whether it was Liang Shi's imagination or not, this time the system's voice carried inexplicable excitement, rather like a "mother whose eldest daughter has finally made something of herself" tone.

[Ding dong dong! Accumulating forty happiness points triggers a passive task: Make handicrafts with Xu Qingzhu once.

Upon completion of this task, all current misfortune points will be cleared, and you'll be rewarded 49,999 yuan.

If the task is overdue/failed, misfortune points +2, triggering a first-level misfortune penalty again, including but not limited to physical injury.

If you want to abandon the task early, you can notify us one day in advance, deducting 2 happiness points with no other effects. Please work hard to complete the task!

PS: Handicrafts and ceramics are both acceptable.

PS again: Making handicrafts can bring two people closer, for example, some intimate contact, holding hands, hugging, and if the host is capable, even some kissing.

PS again again: The host next door has already taken the opportunity of making handicrafts to smooch smooch smooch! Please step up your game, host.]

What's "kissing"?

And what's "smooch smooch smooch"?

These were all blind spots in Liang Shi's knowledge.

The system even provided her with explanations in a sly voice: [Oh my! Kissing means kissing, and smooch smooch smooch means... eek... eek... it means drinking milk! Host, you're so silly. No wonder you can't catch up with the progress next door!]

PS again again again: If the host can increase happiness points to sixty through passive tasks, the system will give an additional five happiness points as a gift.]

Liang Shi: "..."

Was it her imagination?

Why was this system becoming more and more lewd?

Liang Shi didn't understand and didn't want to understand.

However, the system also asked: [Host, do you want to abandon the passive task?]

Liang Shi answered without hesitation: "No."

System: [Alright, the task deadline is this Sunday evening, duration six days. PS: If you can't even complete this, you might as well just die.]

Liang Shi: "..."

Liang Shi cursed the system eight hundred times in her mind.

The inexplicably coquettish system: [Don't secretly badmouth little system! Little system can hear everything! It's just that little system has updated the program algorithm to better meet the host's needs, so it uses this method to answer the host's questions.]

Liang Shi: "..."

She said coldly: "I'm cursing you openly."

System: [Wuwuwu, little system will be sad.]

Liang Shi: "Shut up! Get lost!"

System: [...]

The system instantly returned to seriousness, once again becoming that strange mechanical voice: [Host, keep it up. Little system will take its leave first.]

Liang Shi: "..."

After the system left, Liang Shi began to digest what it had said.

Why had happiness points suddenly accumulated so much? Was it because she had taken care of Xu Qingzhu all night?

Then if Xu Qingzhu got sick in the future and she took care of her every time...

Liang Shi felt this approach might not be sustainable.

She really wanted to find the pattern for accumulating happiness points. Last time happiness points accumulated to 20 was after Xu Qingya came to her house, she made dinner that evening, and lived under the same roof as Xu Qingzhu.

Suddenly she was told that happiness points had been successfully accumulated.

That strange mechanical voice rang out: [Host, the system advises you not to waste your efforts. There's no pattern to happiness point accumulation. Everything is based on emotional accumulation. Your target is the measuring stick for happiness points, so wouldn't it be better to put this energy into pursuing Xu Qingzhu? PS: Those who keep trying to study patterns will ultimately be defeated by patterns.]

The returning system disrupted Liang Shi's thoughts.

However, it also provided Liang Shi with important information: happiness point accumulation depended on Xu Qingzhu's favorability toward her.

There were no specific standards.

Tsk.

Liang Shi decided that filling her stomach was more important.

Chapter 36-3

Breakfast was just simple rice porridge and sandwiches. After Liang Shi finished making them, she called Xu Qingzhu downstairs to eat. She went back upstairs to quickly wash up and change clothes.

Time was too tight, so she only applied a base coat without makeup, and didn't have time to wash her hair either. She casually put it up in a bun, leaving a few strands of hair by her temples.

When she came downstairs, Xu Qingzhu had already finished eating.

"Let's go." Liang Shi directly took her bag and threw the sandwich inside. "I'll drive you to the company."

While changing shoes at the entrance, she asked, "Did you take your medicine?"

Xu Qingzhu was still sick and listless, "I took it."

"Alright, I'll come find you for lunch at noon," Liang Shi said. "Should we eat at your company cafeteria or outside?"

"Outside," Xu Qingzhu said. "There's a sushi place outside our company that's pretty good."

"Okay, make sure you take your medicine and bring the thermos. I put it on the table—there's honeysuckle¹ and goji berries² in it. Remember to drink it." Liang Shi gave detailed instructions. "Also..."

"I brought it, I brought everything," Xu Qingzhu put on her coat. "If we don't leave now, I'll be late, old mother hen."

Liang Shi: "..."

For a moment, she showed a hurt expression.

Xu Qingzhu happened to catch that instant and smiled helplessly, "Alright, I was wrong. Let's go."

Liang Shi still couldn't help nagging, "You had a high fever last night, so you must drink more water today."

Xu Qingzhu nodded, "I know. Don't worry, even if I don't have meetings, I still need to drink water."

Liang Shi: "..."

She didn't really believe that.

But she had given all the reminders she could. Xu Qingzhu wasn't a child and would naturally have her own judgment.

Liang Shi drove Xu Qingzhu to the company first, then watched her go upstairs from downstairs, still not forgetting to remind her, "Call me anytime if you feel unwell."

Xu Qingzhu answered without thinking, "Are you a doctor? I might as well call Zhao Xuning instead of you."

Liang Shi replied, "But it was me who took care of you last night, not Zhao Xuning."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

This accurately deflated Xu Qingzhu's arrogance.

So Xu Qingzhu put on a taught expression, "Okay, thank you, Miss Liang."

Liang Shi: "You're welcome."

"Have a safe trip and a pleasant day at work," Xu Qingzhu said expressionlessly.

Liang Shi: "...Okay."

Footnotes: ¹ Honeysuckle: A traditional Chinese medicinal herb known for its cooling properties and ability to clear heat from the body ² Goji berries: Also known as wolfberries, these are commonly used in traditional Chinese medicine and are believed to boost immunity and energy

Chapter 36-4

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Liang Shi bought a cup of coffee before returning to work at the company. Having stayed up so late last night, her face was somewhat swollen.

Most importantly, she was sleepy.

She clocked in successfully at the last minute. Li Ran had just come to ask her for materials, but when she looked up, Li Ran got a fright.

"Did you go mining last night? Those dark circles are huge." Li Ran complained while still remembering to ask for the materials, "Give me the Version A materials."

Liang Shi quickly found them on her desk and handed them over. Just as she was about to speak, she couldn't help but yawn, "My wife was sick last night, so I didn't sleep all night."

"No way? Even when sick, you could still..." Li Ran's look was suggestive, and even without finishing the sentence, everyone knew what she meant.

Liang Shi was helpless, "She had a high fever. I took care of her all night."

"Okay, okay." Li Ran clicked her tongue, "I thought you were that beastly."

"..."

"By the way, is your wife the one who came to the office to find you last time?" Li Ran suddenly leaned over to gossip in a low voice, "The one who came with General Manager Liang."

Liang Shi nodded, "Yes."

"She's really beautiful." Li Ran said while looking her over, then said sourly, "Sure enough, beauties should be with beauties."

Liang Shi: "..."

That wasn't entirely unreasonable.

Zhou Li walked over and slapped the file folder directly on her shoulder, "Finished with work? Starting to gossip first thing in the morning—I'll send you to the GG group¹."

Li Ran: "..."

She immediately scurried away.

Zhou Li left Liang Shi with the manuscript for Version B Fashion & Style, requiring her to finish it as soon as possible since Zhou Li would still need time to revise it.

Unless Liang Shi was confident enough to pass it in one draft.

Liang Shi knew this was Zhou Li training her, so she said happily, "Sure thing, Sister Li. I'll give it to you before I get off work today."

Zhou Li glanced at her, "You don't need to be that rushed."

But Liang Shi just smiled, full of energy.

Zhou Li returned to her workstation, and Li Ran asked hesitantly, "Sister Li, giving the manuscript to Little Liang—will that work? She has no experience at all."

"It's just five hundred words anyway," Zhou Li said. "Want to write it yourself?"

Li Ran: "...Let Little Liang do it. Let her get some practice."

Zhou Li glanced at Liang Shi, who had already started researching, and suddenly said in a low voice, "Desperate times call for desperate measures. What if she's really buried gold?"

Li Ran agreed, "I suddenly think Little Liang can do it."

Zhou Li: "?"

Li Ran: "Rich young ladies only have entertainment gossip left in their lives."

Zhou Li: "..."

Liang Shi spent the whole morning writing the manuscript. Although it was only five hundred words, she discovered how difficult it was when actually writing.

Because there were so few words, every punctuation mark was particularly important, let alone the actual words.

Despite occupying only a tiny bit of page space, the corresponding content was not simple—the relationship between the entertainment industry and luxury goods.

Liang Shi typed and deleted all morning. When she looked back, she had two hundred and fifty words.

Another hundred and fifty were unusable.

Near lunchtime, she deleted another sixty words, leaving only forty words in the end.

It wasn't until everyone went for lunch that she closed her computer and went out.

Li Ran asked her, "Little Liang, what are you eating for lunch?"

"I'm going out to eat," Liang Shi said. "Sister Ran, you all go ahead and eat, don't worry about me."

Li Ran suddenly had an epiphany, "Are you going to find your wife?"

Liang Shi: "...Yes."

So everyone cast teasing smiles and started making jokes.

"Next time we have a group dinner, bring your wife along."

"Who would have thought our Little Liang is such a model wife²."

"Little Liang, hurry up and go, don't mind them."

"..."

Everyone burst into laughter, and Liang Shi left with red ears.

After she left, everyone continued discussing.

"You can't tell at all that Little Liang is a rich young lady—she doesn't put on any airs."

"Yeah, she's completely different from when she first came to the magazine department. Much more kind."

"Especially compared to the previous rumors, she's like a completely different person."

"Rumors stop with the wise."

"..."

Footnotes: ¹ GG group: Likely referring to a less desirable work group or department (GG often means "game over" in internet slang) ² Model wife: The literal translation is "twenty-four filial good wife," referring to the traditional Chinese concept of twenty-four examples of filial piety, here used to describe someone as an exemplary, devoted spouse

Chapter 36-5

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Liang Shi drove directly to the restaurant she and Xu Qingzhu had agreed on.

When she arrived, Sally and Cherry were also there, and Sally kept staring at her with very profound eyes.

Liang Shi felt uncomfortable being stared at and couldn't help asking, "Sally, is there something on my face?"

"No," Sally said. "Why did you come to eat near our company?"

Liang Shi: "...To supervise Xu Qingzhu."

Sally said matter-of-factly, "Cherry and I can do that too. Tell me, did you come because of that mistress?"

Liang Shi: "?"

Who?

Mistress?

She looked confused, and Xu Qingzhu coughed lightly beside her as a reminder, "Zhou Yi'an."

Liang Shi: "..."

Liang Shi rubbed her temples with a headache and picked up a piece of sushi that had just been served to give to Sally, "Please, Sally, spare me. Don't ruin my reputation."

Sally circled back to the question, "Then why did you come?"

And she analyzed confidently, "When the mistress doesn't come, you don't come. As soon as the mistress comes, you have to run over at lunchtime. If you say it's not because of the mistress, I don't believe it!"

"You're the mistress," Zhou Yi'an's voice suddenly rang out from behind, carrying a sinister tone that startled Sally.

Lin Luoxi turned around, her tone provocative, "Did we call your name?"

Zhou Yi'an clicked her tongue, "When you're talking about this in front of my darling, you're naturally talking about me."

Liang Shi: "...Shut up."

She looked at Zhou Yi'an expressionlessly, and Zhou Yi'an glanced at her then at Xu Qingzhu, "My darling really knows how to care for people."

Liang Shi raised an eyebrow and sneered, "Haven't gone crazy enough yet?"

Her tone of voice was nine-tenths similar to that night, and the smile on her face was the same as that night too, with a few traces of intense interest in her eyes, as if saying—if you haven't gone crazy enough, then I'll accompany you for another round of madness.

The fear of being dominated by Liang Shi that night, when she had pushed her down with her own hands, surged up from the depths of her memory.

Zhou Yi'an clenched her hands hanging at her sides into fists, "Darling, I'm not crazy."

"Then shut up," Liang Shi said. "Stop disgusting me, or I won't be able to eat later."

Zhou Yi'an: "..."

She looked deeply at Liang Shi, then smiled, "Fine, you all eat. I'm leaving."

After saying this, she looked at Sally again and threatened in English, "Watch what you say in the future. Don't slander people."

Sally was defiant, "But aren't you interfering in someone else's marriage?! Blanche and Liang Shi are already married. If your behavior isn't being a mistress, what is it?"

Zhou Yi'an paused for two seconds, her tone cold, "Only those who succeed in interfering are mistresses."

Sally: "?"

Zhou Yi'an sneered, "At most, I'm just toying with her."

Cherry: "..."

Lin Luoxi had originally taken a sip of orange juice, but upon hearing this, she spat it out. Sally immediately handed her tissues.

After Lin Luoxi wiped the water stains from the corner of her mouth, she said, "You're quite self-aware."

Before she finished speaking, Zhou Yi'an had already left.

She had just come to pack a box of sushi and then continued back to draw.

Sally and Cherry both stared at Xu Qingzhu, but Xu Qingzhu showed no reaction. Even though the atmosphere between them and Zhou Yi'an had just been full of sparks and lightning, ready to fight at any moment, Xu Qingzhu was completely unaffected. She had eaten six pieces of sushi and was still drinking miso soup.

Sally: "You really have a big heart."

Cherry: "Impressive¹."

Xu Qingzhu raised an eyebrow, took a tissue to wipe the corner of her mouth, "The group meeting starts at two."

The two who had been eating leisurely immediately started eating quickly.

But Sally ate a lot and didn't let that stop her from continuing to ask, "Liang Shi, do you and that Zhou Yi'an really have nothing going on?"

Liang Shi was helpless, "What could there be? I don't like her. Besides, I'm already married."

Sally asked, "Then who do you like?"

Liang Shi: "..."

She was silent for two seconds, then answered vaguely, "Whoever you marry, that's who you like."

Lin Luoxi stopped eating halfway through and put down her chopsticks, "That's fallacious reasoning."

Liang Shi: "..."

Then what else was she supposed to say?

"Can't you like our Zhu Zi?" Sally said. "You can't even firmly say you like Zhu Zi?"

"I can," Liang Shi said. "The person I like is..."

"Alright," Xu Qingzhu interrupted her, rescuing her from the situation, "Can't eating shut you all up? You're not eating, but Liang Shi still needs to eat."

Sally immediately turned sour, "We haven't even done anything to her yet, and you're already protecting her!"

Xu Qingzhu sat by the window, outside which were the towering CBD buildings reaching into the clouds. The glass was cleaned very thoroughly, and the afternoon sunlight streamed in, falling on her.

She half-closed her eyes to bask in the sun, her tone clear and cold, her speech slow but carrying a hint of teasing, "If I don't protect my wife, am I supposed to protect you?"

Sally clutched her heart, expressing her heartbreak.

Xu Qingzhu said airily, "Don't delay my wife's meal."

As she spoke, she used her chopsticks to pick up a piece of sushi for Liang Shi.

Liang Shi looked at the sushi on her plate and thought to herself: Xu Qingzhu's acting skills have improved by leaps and bounds.

She's at the level where she could enter the entertainment industry and be nominated for Best Actress any day now.

Footnotes: ¹ "Impressive" - The original Chinese "狼滅" appears to be internet slang, possibly a typo or variation of "厲害" (impressive/awesome)

Chapter 36-6

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Liang Shi didn't take that lunchtime incident to heart, but she was somewhat worried that Xu Qingzhu couldn't handle Zhou Yi'an.

However, Xu Qingzhu reassured her that since it was her own home turf, there was no way Zhou Yi'an could bully her.

As Liang Shi was driving away, she happened to encounter Zhou Yi'an.

She was standing by the roadside smoking, holding a cup of coffee in her hand. Her shoulder-length short hair was blowing in the wind, and the leather jacket she wore displayed her rebellious individuality.

When Liang Shi looked over, she happened to make eye contact with Zhou Yi'an.

Liang Shi immediately looked away, and in that instant, Zhou Yi'an's lips curved up in a very wicked smile.

After a while, as Liang Shi's car drove away from that street, she received a text message from an unknown number: [Darling, you seem to have become good.]

[How can a crazy person become good?]

[When you were crazy, even your eyes weren't as ruthless as before.]

[Darling, do people become good after marrying the person they love?]

[So would you consider marrying me? I can become a good person for you.]

Liang Shi: "..."

Without even thinking, she knew this was from Zhou Yi'an.

Liang Shi only replied with one word: [Scram.]

Then she blocked that number.

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Liang Shi struggled to complete the task Zhou Li had assigned her. That 500-word article wasn't finished until almost time to get off work.

She was trembling with fear when she submitted it, but Zhou Li glanced at it and said it was pretty good—it passed.

So she still got off work on time.

She kept her promise to Xu Qingzhu and went to pick her up from work, but Miss Xu Qingzhu, in preparation for the smooth launch of the autumn new product release, was still working overtime at the company.

In fact, their entire company was working overtime.

After Liang Shi arrived, she waited in Xu Qingzhu's office.

After their meeting ended, it was around eight o'clock.

Only then did Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu leave the company. Before leaving, they encountered Zhou Yi'an again.

Zhou Yi'an raised an eyebrow and spun half a circle in her office chair, smiling wickedly: "Liang Shi, would your wife die if she didn't work overtime?"

Xu Qingzhu glanced at her, "Designer Zhou, you can get off work now."

Zhou Yi'an stood up but also picked up her iPad, "The company's overtime culture is really ridiculous."

Xu Qingzhu: "You can leave once you finish your own work. I'm not forcing you."

Zhou Yi'an: "..."

Zhou Yi'an walked away looking aggressive, leaving the colleagues awkwardly standing in place.

Xu Qingzhu also told everyone to hurry up and get off work.

On the way back, Xu Qingzhu curled up in the passenger seat to rest.

Liang Shi asked, "Is Zhou Yi'an difficult to manage?"

"She's alright," Xu Qingzhu thought about Zhou Yi'an's design drafts and suddenly sighed, "She really is very talented."

Liang Shi: "..."

"Her design drafts are very inspired," Xu Qingzhu said objectively, "She's a natural talent."

Liang Shi: "Can't tell."

"So judging a person based solely on appearance is still very narrow-minded," Xu Qingzhu said.

After that, they fell into silence.

Xu Qingzhu was extremely tired and even took a nap in the car.

When they got home, Xu Qingzhu went upstairs to wash up while Liang Shi cooked dinner.

Dinner was also simple—Liang Shi just stir-fried some vegetables, pan-fried two eggs, and steamed rice.

Liang Shi worked quickly. While Xu Qingzhu hadn't come downstairs yet, she returned to her room to change clothes and do some simple washing up.

By the time Xu Qingzhu was eating, she was already somewhat drowsy. She casually picked at her food a few times, and only after Liang Shi finished eating did she start to clear the table.

Liang Shi immediately stopped her, but was held down by her, "You cook, I wash dishes. That's very fair."

Liang Shi: "..."

"You go wash up. I'll go back to my room to sleep after I finish washing the dishes," Xu Qingzhu said.

Liang Shi agreed.

When Xu Qingzhu came out after washing the dishes, she saw Liang Shi's watch on the dining table, but looking around, Liang Shi was no longer in the living room or dining room.

She had probably returned to her room.

Xu Qingzhu was worried she wouldn't be able to find it, so she went to deliver it to her. However, when she knocked on her room door, no one answered. She pushed the door open, "I'm coming in."

The door wasn't locked and opened with a push.

No one was in the room either, but there was the sound of water coming from the bathroom.

Xu Qingzhu glanced over but couldn't see anything.

She figured Liang Shi was taking a shower, so she placed the watch on the nightstand, where Liang Shi's phone was also placed.

...

Xu Qingzhu suddenly remembered what Dr. Gu had said—perhaps she could start with the phone's memo and diary.

She glanced guiltily toward the bathroom. Liang Shi should still be showering for quite a while.

This was a good opportunity.

But prying into someone else's privacy was something Xu Qingzhu had never done in her entire life.

She found it somewhat unacceptable.

But there were too many mysteries surrounding Liang Shi. Xu Qingzhu wanted to know whether she had a dual personality, or whether she knew she had a dual personality.

Chapter 36-7

...

After hesitating for a long time, Xu Qingzhu still picked up Liang Shi's phone with trembling hands.

The lock screen password was Liang Shi's birthday, which she easily unlocked.

Then she clicked into the memo app—it was completely blank.

There was also her WeChat, which had very few contacts, completely different from Liang Shi's previous WeChat where she could casually call upon friends at will.

Even though Xu Qingzhu had never checked Liang Shi's phone before, she had inadvertently glimpsed it, and her contact list had at least over a thousand people.

But the current account was simple and clean, just like her processed social media feed.

Xu Qingzhu still couldn't find any clues.

This was her first time doing such a thing. Her palms were sweaty and trembling. In the end, she didn't know what she accidentally clicked on, but it brought up an encrypted folder.

She didn't know how many digits the password was.

Xu Qingzhu first entered Liang Shi's birthday—incorrect.

She then entered her own birthday—also incorrect.

After that, she tried some other dates that were relatively important to Liang Shi, but none of them worked.

Xu Qingzhu suddenly thought of their wedding anniversary.

So she entered that string of numbers, but it was still incorrect.

She had already given up. When she was about to exit, there was a reminder: it's two dates added together.

So she tried Liang Shi's birthday plus her own birthday, then tried Liang Shi's birthday plus their wedding anniversary.

Both were wrong.

Without much hope, she entered her own birthday plus their wedding anniversary.

...And it opened.

Xu Qingzhu was shocked beyond belief. She never would have expected it to be this string of numbers.

She didn't have time to think too much about it and quickly opened the folder. One after another, they were all empty documents, like nesting dolls¹. When she clicked to the very end, there was only one photo.

—It was an extremely dim room that emanated a ghostly red glow. The ceiling was arched, somewhat resembling a coffin lid. On the floor of the room were rows of unlit white candles, the bed was covered with a layer of hell money², and the person in the photo wore an oversized white mourning dress, sitting in the middle of the bed. Those eyes stared at the camera with an empty and lifeless gaze, lips parted to reveal white teeth in a bone-chillingly terrifying smile.

The base tone was dark, but the center was white.

And in the bottom right corner of this photo were two words—Sacrificial Offering.

The person in the photo was Liang Shi, but much more immature than now.

She should have been quite young.

Xu Qingzhu broke out in a cold sweat from fright.

"Why are you here?" Liang Shi's voice suddenly rang out, accompanied by the sound of the bathroom door closing.

Xu Qingzhu was startled and immediately switched the phone back to the main interface, then said, "Your... your phone was left outside, I... I helped bring it in for you."

"You could have just brought it in," Liang Shi said puzzledly, "Why are you so nervous?"

"I'm not... not..." Xu Qingzhu almost bit her tongue off. She swallowed, "You should... sleep early. I'm going upstairs. Good night."

After saying this, without waiting for Liang Shi to respond, she rushed out of the room like a gust of wind, not forgetting to close the door behind her.

And Liang Shi's memory certainly wasn't that poor.

She had come in playing with her phone after dinner.

So obviously, Xu Qingzhu had just checked her phone.

But the problem was that she had already cleared everything. There were pitifully few apps on her phone, and she had even deleted those few sentences from the original owner's memo.

She opened her phone and checked the recently opened applications.

Then she saw that photo.

...

This was Liang Shi's first time seeing it.

The first glance at the photo startled her, because that person with a face identical to her teenage self was sitting in the middle of the bed, showing a sinister smile, like a puppet being controlled by someone.

It was horrifying enough to belong in a horror movie.

But there was only this one photo on the phone, nothing else.

Liang Shi saved it, then exited and tried to open that folder again, only to discover it was encrypted.

...

She had to admire Xu Qingzhu.

And that night, Liang Shi had another dream.

In the dream were too many bizarre scenes, but what left the deepest impression on her was the small bamboo house in the mountains.

It was a rather beautiful mountain, with lush green grass on the mountainside and a clear stream at the foot of the mountain. The stream water wound around the base of the mountain, nourishing the creatures living on the mountain.

From the foot of the mountain all the way up, at the halfway point stood a lonely small bamboo house. Inside the bamboo house sat a middle-aged man wearing blue-green robes with a very long beard.

Qiu Zimin pulled the young Liang Shi to the middle-aged man, "Sir, how do you think this person's qualifications are?"

"Passable," the other party said.

And the young Liang Shi was left outside the bamboo house.

From inside the bamboo house came the sound of Qiu Zimin and the middle-aged man conversing.

"If I turn her into a sacrificial offering, it will make the Liang family prosperous and successful?" Qiu Zimin asked.

The middle-aged man said, "Isn't she your daughter? Are you willing to give her up?"

Footnotes: ¹ Nesting dolls: Refers to Russian matryoshka dolls that nest inside one another, used metaphorically here to describe folders within folders ² Hell money: Paper money burned as offerings to deceased ancestors in Chinese traditional beliefs, also known as "ghost money" or "spirit money"